

Against Unconditional Love

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ABSTRACT *While unconditional love is frequently regarded as the best kind of romantic commitment, our commitments in general are not thought to be unconditional. In other contexts, we think conditional commitment (commitment which can in some sense be rendered intelligible by appeal to reasons) to be superior. This paper examines the peculiar status of unconditional love in the romantic context and argues that it is unwarranted; the best kind of romantic commitment should be viewed as conditional. The first part of the paper examines and criticises those arguments which attempt to defend conditional love by appeal to the idea that love is based upon the properties of the beloved. The second part of the paper examines Harry Frankfurt's narrowly subjective conception of unconditional love and highlights certain counterintuitive consequences of it. The final section of the paper argues that the best kind of love will prompt us to adopt two perspectives with regard to the beloved. While loving does involve the narrowly subjective perspective defended by Frankfurt, it also demands that we strive for a more objective perspective, which takes into consideration the reasons we might be able to offer to render our commitment intelligible to others.*

'Whatever my man is, I'm his forevermore.' [1]

So ends the jazz standard, 'My Man', perhaps most famously performed by Billie Holiday. Such professions of unconditional love are often taken to epitomise the romantic ideal. When one commits oneself to love unconditionally, one declares an intention to love the beloved come what may, for better or for worse. And we very often think of this as the best kind of love, as the purest kind of commitment one can make. The thought, I suppose, is that it is somewhat offensive, objectionably contractual and dispassionate to suggest that one will love, but only so long as the beloved retains her youthful appearance, her sense of humour, his easy-going demeanour or his impeccable hygiene. Of course we hope that our beloved *will* retain the qualities we adore in him or her, but it seems rather unforgiving to suggest that we shall only love so long as he or she does. To many of us, conditional commitment actually bespeaks a misguided understanding of what it is to love; we would surely wonder whether an individual who was able to present her beloved with a list of terms and conditions upon which the continuation of her love would depend was truly in love at all. It is not difficult to see why unconditional love is felt by many to describe a form of commitment superior to the conditional alternatives.

But when romantic love is viewed within the wider context of commitment in general, this begins to seem a rather peculiar conclusion. For example, we would surely not regard an unconditional commitment to social justice as being necessarily superior to a more questioning and critical commitment. Indeed, we would probably think the

person who took an interest in finding reasons to support her commitment to the cause of social justice a more devoted adherent than the person who simply insisted that he was committed to the cause for better or for worse. In cases such as this, the profession of unconditional commitment sounds, more than anything, like an excuse for apathy with regard to the object of one's devotion. Thus, we generally think of conditional commitment not as impoverished, but, on the contrary, as a superior way of relating to the things we care about. It implies an active concern and positive engagement with the object. This being the case, why does the species of commitment known as 'love', and romantic love in particular, have this peculiar 'untouchable' status? Perhaps it is because, as Gabrielle Taylor suggests, '[w]e tend to think of love as so great a good that it seems sacrilegious to raise the possibility of it being unjustified under some circumstances' [2]. Surely though, as Taylor recognises, this kind of thought should be disregarded as so much hyper-romantic nonsense. For love is not always so great a good.

While the song, 'My Man', concludes with a romantic-sounding profession of unconditional love, some of the earlier lyrics may give us pause for thought:

Two or three girls
Has he
That he likes as well as me,
But I love him.

I don't know why I should,
He isn't true,
He beats me, too.
What can I do? [3]

What initially appeared as an expression of a superior commitment — 'whatever my man is, I'm his' — is transformed into a defiant (or foolhardy) refusal to take seriously the failings of the beloved; a stubborn resistance to the authority of reasons, whatever those reasons may be, in the name of unconditional love. Are we to understand 'My Man' as a love song? To me it is unclear. It certainly seems as though we might accuse the singer's 'man' of failing to understand what it is to love. But is it legitimate to claim that the singer does not love? It is tempting to say that if she is willing to submit herself to the kind of life she describes, then she must, if nothing else, be in love. But this is surely an unsatisfactory answer; love in this case does not seem a great good and the singer's devotion seems misplaced. In this paper I want to provide some kind of philosophical support for this view. I shall argue that we can say that the singer's love is impoverished on the ground that it is unconditional. In this way, then, I shall attempt to draw love into a more consistent relation with the other species of commitment.

The paper is divided into three parts. In the first part, I shall address a hotly debated issue in the philosophical literature concerning love, which would appear to bear upon the question regarding the conditionality of love and that is whether or not love is ultimately based upon the properties of the beloved. I shall argue that any remotely plausible properties-based account of love says nothing significant about its conditionality; if we want to criticise unconditional love, we shall have to look elsewhere. In the second part of the paper, I shall focus upon a specific account of love, which has been

propounded by Harry Frankfurt. By drawing attention to some of the flaws in his account, I shall attempt to defend the intuitive superiority of conditional love in the romantic context. In the third part, I shall attempt to develop this point further by highlighting the virtues of an account of romantic love which makes conditionality central. In this way, I hope to show that unconditional love of the kind promised by the jazz singer is not the best kind of love there can be.

Love and Properties: Those Obscure Deities

1. For Marcel Proust, love 'is a striking example of how little reality means to us' [4]. And, indeed, while it seems true that, in love, we are initially captivated by certain properties we believe the beloved to possess — for why else, as Robert Nozick wonders, 'was not a different person loved just as well?' [5] — as the romantic attachment deepens, the relevance of the beloved's characteristics becomes rather more obscure. As Nozick proceeds to explain, 'eventually you must love the person himself, and not *for* the characteristics . . . [I]f we continue to be loved "for" the characteristics, then the love seems conditional, something that might change or disappear if the characteristics do' [6]. Still, however, the idea that the properties of the beloved must have some role to play in our loving as we do has considerable intuitive force. And, recently, a number of theorists have argued that love can be explained entirely in terms of the properties of the beloved [7]. Even for Proust, the thought that properties must have some role to play in romantic love, in spite of their opacity, runs deep. As the narrator explains of the women he had loved:

It was as though a virtue that had no connexion with them had been artificially attached to them by nature, and that this virtue, this quasi-electric power, had the effect upon me of exciting my love, that is to say of controlling all my actions and causing all my sufferings. But from this, the beauty, or the intelligence, or the kindness of these women was entirely distinct . . . [B]eneath the outward appearance of the woman, it is to those invisible forces with which she is incidentally accompanied that we address ourselves as to obscure deities [8].

Proust, then, remains agnostic. He denies that we love for the sake of any clearly identifiable properties possessed by the beloved, but he still seems to want to maintain that the beloved possesses *something* — those 'obscure deities' — which can explain our love.

The role of properties in attachments of romantic love would seem to impinge quite directly upon the question of the conditionality of love. If we love wholly upon the basis of a 'shopping list' of qualities, it seems that love must necessarily be conditional: as the qualities for which we love disappear, so too must the love. If the properties account can be vindicated, then it seems we might be able to criticise the jazz singer's attachment on the ground that she recognises that her man lacks any properties which might explain her love for him; her devotion would thus be irrational. In this section, I want to try to clarify the issues involved in the love and properties debate, though I fear that I cannot promise to offer much that is decisive. I shall begin by rejecting swiftly the rather crude properties account: that view of love which makes the shopping

list of properties fundamental. I shall then consider a rather more sophisticated version of the account and shall address its implications for the conditionality of love.

2. The extreme version of the properties view says something like the following: I love the person who possesses properties x , y , and z , and I shall remain in love so long as he or she retains properties x , y and z . Should he or she lose these properties, the basis for loving will also be lost, taking with it any reason I might have had to remain committed. I think this view must be rejected for its failure to reflect our experience of love. We would certainly like to think, and very often it is the case, that love's bond is stronger and far less conditional than this kind of properties account would seem to imply. Consider, for example, the attachment of John Bayley to his wife, Iris Murdoch. Even though (one presumes) one of the chief properties for which Bayley found Murdoch lovable was her intellect, it is just not the case that he ceased to love her as she sank deeper into the grip of Alzheimer's. Indeed, it does not seem to be the case that Bayley's love for Murdoch was even slightly weakened with the loss of those properties for which he had fallen in love with her. In fact, it is tempting to say that Murdoch's characteristics had no relevance whatsoever: Bayley's commitment was unconditional, and his love would have endured perhaps any change in the beloved.

3. So, in its extreme form, the property-based account fails to satisfy. But I think there is perhaps a little more that can be said yet for a subtler version of the view. While it seems phenomenologically inaccurate to suppose that we begin a commitment with a set of criteria to which our partner must live up or face rejection, this need not refute the properties account. For a start, why must we suppose that the criteria for which we love must always remain static? People clearly change and are indeed often transformed by the experience of loving. As a result, one's character and the qualities one values in another are both liable and likely to change. For this reason, it would not in fact, even on the properties view, be open to us to say to the beloved that, for instance, 'I will love you, but only so long as you are passionate about "having it large" in the nightclubs of Ibiza during the summer months', for whether my love will *always* be conditional upon the beloved's possession of *that* property is far from clear. This is especially so, I think, when it comes to mutual romantic relationships and as a result we might be able to ease the property theorist's concern about John Bayley's apparently boundless love for Iris Murdoch. As Simon Keller, who defends a property-based account of romantic love, has observed, '[t]he love of a romantic partner can be a source of personal transformation. . . . As a partner in a romantic relationship, I might change into someone who can compromise, who thinks of others before he acts, and who is able to engage in constructive argument' [9]. It is thus always possible that, as the beloved changes, we may change with him or her and, as Keller continues:

As romantic partners change together, they come to share a system of values and a way of looking at the world. The process of shared change is such that your beloved will come to value the properties that you value, and you will come to value the properties that she has [10].

While we should be careful not to exaggerate this point — I do not doubt that there exist many long-devoted couples who argue fiercely about certain values — this rendition of the properties account does allow the possibility that Bayley's love for Murdoch

could have been based upon her properties. To be sure, the properties for which he loved her would have changed over time, but that is hardly surprising given that *he* was changing over time. In part because of his love for Murdoch and because of the way in which he was changed by the life he shared with her, Bayley's outlook evolved and, as a result, the qualities he found he valued in others were transformed.

To this it might be objected that it is not the case that the love endures because the properties the lover values have changed, but rather that the reverse is true: the properties the lover finds lovable change just because the love endures. For example, when I cite, as a lovable property of my beloved, the adorable way in which she dribbles as she sleeps, it is just as plausible (if not more so) to say that I love that property just because it is she who possesses it, as it is to say that I love her because she possesses that property. While I am inclined to favour the former view — that we have a tendency to find our beloved's properties lovable just because we love him or her — it is not clear to me that anything decisive can be said on the issue. But in any case, why must the properties theorist insist that the lover must know what his or her criteria for loving are? [11] Very often we have no idea why we feel as we do; very often we claim to love the beloved for properties he or she does not in fact possess. None of this means that love is not based upon properties; all it means is that love is mysterious.

4. However, there are other reasons for us to doubt the plausibility of the properties account. As Susan Mendus has argued:

If I now claim to be committed to my husband I precisely cannot give an exhaustive account of the characteristics he possesses in virtue of which I have that commitment to him: if I could do so, there would be a real question as to why I am not prepared to show the same commitment to another person who shares those characteristics (his twin brother, for example) [12].

If, that is to say, love is entirely dependent upon the properties of the beloved, why do I love him or her, but not anybody else who possesses the same qualities? This objection can be deflected to some extent by pointing out that, as a matter of fact, we are not going to find another person who possesses precisely the same complex of properties. Even the twin brother is going to be significantly different in crucial respects, thereby providing a rationale in terms of properties for our not loving him as we love the beloved. However, while important, this does not explain why we are not, hypothetically, prepared to love the *absolutely* identical other; even though we will never be confronted with the choice, it remains important to many of us to believe that we would not be so prepared.

Perhaps the answer to this puzzle — why I love my beloved, but not her doppelganger — lies in the fact of our shared history [13]. My beloved will have contributed to my life story in a particular manner; she has played a formative role in my identity and this, the doppelganger could not have done or not, at least, in the same way. So, the beloved is differentiated from the doppelganger by the unique contribution she has made to the narrative of my life. And this contribution cannot be entirely captured, it would seem, in an account of the properties of the beloved. As Joseph Raz has argued 'uniqueness is not in . . . [the beloved's] intrinsic and qualitative properties. It is past dependent. It is in its . . . [and the lover's] past actions and decisions' [14].

Still, however, the extremity of the example upon which one must rely — doppelgangers, robots and so forth [15] — to deliver this conclusion, might prompt us to doubt its validity. While I find myself more sympathetic to those accounts of love which see it grounded in something more than just the properties of the beloved, I am not clear that the objections I have considered here amount to a clear refutation of the properties account. Perhaps it is best that we conclude with Proust that these deities are obscure indeed.

One point that can be made more decisively, though, is that none of this impinges very much upon the conditionality of love. We set out with the view that the properties account implied conditionality. But, on the more sophisticated version I have attempted to articulate, it becomes apparent that love for properties is not necessarily conditional, or not at least in a counterintuitive manner. For on the more elaborate account it is not open to the lover to say, for example, 'I shall love you so long as you retain your youth and good looks, but no longer', for this is not something that the lover for properties can actually know. For sure it is true that, on the properties account, it is open to the lover to say, 'I shall love you only so long as you display lovable properties', but this is not a condition of the same order at all; indeed, it is really no different from the lover saying, in accordance with a non-property-based account, that 'I shall love you so long as you do not display a quality which undermines my love for you'.

So the properties account does not deliver conditionality in the manner we may have hoped it would. Reasons for loving, that is to say, cannot be grounded in an appeal to the properties of the beloved; for in so far as love can plausibly be understood as based upon properties at all, those properties are far too obscure to be of any assistance to us. I thus propose now to change tack and to explore further the structure and nature of love in the hope that we might be able to locate a source of legitimate conditions which may serve to distinguish the best kind of love.

Conditional Love

1. It is my view that the best kind of love involves conditionality (albeit a somewhat peculiar kind of conditionality) on the ground that genuine care and concern for the beloved prompts its imposition. In this section, I shall explain how this is the case. The condition is peculiar, for it is not one that we impose upon the beloved in the manner implied by the properties account of love; as I argued in the previous section: that would be contrary to loving. Instead, I want to suggest that it is a condition we impose essentially upon *ourselves*. And the condition is this: that we, *qua* lovers, shall continue to love in the best way so long as we are prepared to strive to enrich that love by engaging in an inquiry into the value of that love, but no longer. In other words, imposing the condition amounts to an acceptance of the idea that it is a part of the best kind of love that the lover takes an interest in the non-subjective worth of her beloved. It is a declaration that, at the point at which the lover loses interest in striving to confirm the worth of the beloved, she has ceased to love as much as she once had. In order to show why we should want to impose this condition, I shall examine and criticise the account of love propounded by Harry Frankfurt.

Before I begin to describe Frankfurt's account of love it is worth mentioning that his use of the term is not entirely conventional. He describes it as a particular mode of

caring and, as such, its objects are broader than we might expect. For instance, Frankfurt speaks of love not only for one's partner or children, but also for one's friends, one's country and one's ideals. He does not deny that there are vast differences between the love one has for one's children and the love one has for, say, social justice, but he insists that all species of love share a common volitional structure. So while the focus of my paper is upon romantic love, it should be possible to generalise the claims discussed to make them applicable to all varieties of love.

2. While Frankfurt stresses that he will not 'even attempt to provide anything like a comprehensive analysis of the range of diverse and complex phenomena that . . . [loving] includes' [16], he does provide the following rough definition:

Love is a *disinterested* concern for the flourishing of what is loved. That is, the lover desires the good of his beloved; and he desires it for its own sake, rather than for the sake of promoting any other interests [17].

Furthermore, Frankfurt understands love as being, in an important sense, involuntary. We cannot help loving what we love. Indeed, it is surely true that we would think it rather odd if, other things being equal, the lover found it necessary to pause for thought before, say, going to comfort his or her beloved when he or she was upset. It seems wholly appropriate that there are certain things we simply *must* do, actions we take instinctively for the sake of those we love. As Frankfurt explains:

There are occasions when a person realizes that what he cares about matters to him not merely so much, but in such a way, that it is impossible for him to forbear from a certain course of action. It was presumably on such an occasion, for example, that Luther made his famous declaration: 'Here I stand; I can do no other' [18].

But, as I have implied, such encounters with necessity need not always be so dramatic as Luther's; the way in which the objects of our love necessitate us is subtler than the example might suggest. We construct our lives around the things we love and care about. As Frankfurt explains, '[l]ove is . . . a source of reasons. It creates the reasons by which acts of loving devotion are inspired. As a matter of fact, that's precisely how it is that love makes the world go around' [19].

Consider, for example, Meaulnes' quest for the woman he loves, Yvonne de Galais, in Alain-Fournier's *Le Grand Meaulnes*. We can recognise the way in which love impels us to act in Meaulnes' description of the vigil he cannot help but hold by the window of a house his beloved had once occupied:

I still pass by that window. I still wait without a spark of hope. And I know it's mad. These cold Sunday afternoons of autumn, when the light begins to fail, I can never make up my mind to go back to my room and close the shutters for the night till I've been to that bleak street again [20].

However, Meaulnes' recognition that his behaviour is 'mad' highlights a lacuna in any account of love cast purely in terms of impulsion. For how, on any such account, are we to distinguish between love and infatuation? Meaulnes' diagnosis of madness implies that he may not be in love at all; that, rather, he may just be foolishly obsessed. Indeed, it seems important that we be able to make a distinction here. It cannot be the

case that what we admire about Luther's stand, or that what we admire about the lover who comforts his or her beloved, can be entirely explained by the fact that the action was involuntary. We would surely think less of the lover who comforts us if she revealed that she *literally* could have behaved in no other way, that, like Meaulnes, she regarded her behaviour as a kind of madness. We would surely like to believe that not only did our lover regard comforting us a necessity, but also it was a necessity she *endorsed*. Frankfurt recognises this second facet of loving when he draws a distinction between love, which he says 'captivates' us, and passion, which he says 'enslaves' us [21]. Again, this seems to me to be accurate. Certainly we would generally take there to be some significant difference between a person impelled to act upon the dictates of an obsessive infatuation and a person impelled to act upon the dictates of love, but how is this difference to be spelled out?

Frankfurt's view is that it has to do with whether or not the agent is able authentically to identify with what he or she is doing. As he explains, if there is 'no discrepancy between what we must do and how we would in any event wish to behave . . . [then] the irresistible force [of love] is not alien to us at all' [22]. For Frankfurt, then, love is a configuration of the will. Where I am able *authentically* to identify with the way in which I am impelled to act, I love. Where I do not endorse my behaviour, I am enslaved by passion. This is a highly subjective account of love, one which consists entirely in my being true to myself. The implication of this is that the continuation of love has nothing to do with the non-subjective worth of the beloved or, connectedly, with the existence of 'reasons to love'. As Frankfurt explains:

If I ask myself whether my children are worthy of my love, my quite emphatic inclination is simply to reject the question as inappropriate and misguided. This is not because it goes without saying that they *are* worthy. It is because my love for them is in no way a response to or based upon any evaluation of them or of the consequences for me of loving them. If my children should turn out to be ferociously wicked, and if it should also become apparent that loving them threatened my hope of leading a decent life, I might come to feel that it was in some way regrettable that I loved them. But I suspect that after recognizing all this, I would continue to love them anyhow [23].

But clearly it is not the case that the love of parents for their children will necessarily last forever. Love, in any of its forms, can and does end. But if love is impervious to reasons, what, on Frankfurt's account, can explain the end of love? Frankfurt argues that the continuation of love is dependent upon the maintenance of a kind of integrity of the will and that this integrity 'can be undermined by radical discrepancies among the objects that we love. Disorders of that sort rupture the unity of the will and put us at odds with ourselves; they make it impossible for us to plot a steady volitional course' [24]. This disruption, this conflict between the things we care about and love can prompt us to try to bring about the conditions that would cause us to stop loving.

Imagine, for example, a person in romantic love who discovers that his beloved has a compulsive tendency to lie. For Frankfurt, such a discovery could not constitute a reason to cease loving as loving does not depend upon reasons. In order for the discovery to affect his commitment to the beloved, it would have to be the case that he cared about honesty. If this were so, he would experience a rupture in the unity of his will; his commitment to honesty would point in one direction, his commitment to

his beloved would point in another. At minimum, this would provoke a sense of unease and perhaps he could live with that, but it could potentially plunge him into crisis. To resolve the crisis he would have, as Proust put it, to commit the 'slow and painful suicide of that self which loved' [25]; he would have to attempt to bring about the conditions that would cause him to cease caring either for his beloved, or for honesty. Of course, the end of love may not always take quite this form. It is not always open to us, or necessary for us, to commit the suicide of which Proust writes. Sometimes, we just find that we have ceased to love. Suddenly we view the beloved in an entirely different light which engenders an instant transformation of our feelings for him or her [26]. Consider, for example, Fermina Daza's reunion with her beloved Florentino Ariza in Gabriel García Márquez's *Love in the Time of Cholera*:

She turned her head and saw, a hand's breadth from her eyes, those other glacial eyes, that livid face, those lips petrified with fear, just as she had seen them in the crowd at Midnight Mass the first time he was so close to her, but now, instead of the commotion of love, she felt the abyss of disenchantment. In an instant the magnitude of her own mistake was revealed to her, and she asked herself, appalled, how she could have nurtured such a chimera in her heart for so long and with so much ferocity [27].

However we describe the end of love, though, I suspect Frankfurt's explanation of it will be much the same. We have discovered that we care about something else as much as or more than the beloved and this prompts us to view, or to try to view, the beloved in a different light.

3. But where does this leave the jazz singer who professes that she will love her man whatever he is? On Frankfurt's account she cannot be mistaken to suppose that her man is worth loving, for it is the fact that she loves him that *makes* him worth loving for her. As Frankfurt says, '[w]hat we love *acquires* value for us just *because we love it*. The value derives from and depends upon the love' [28]. She implies that her will is not entirely unified when she sings, on one hand, 'I don't know why I should [love him]', yet, on the other, 'When he takes me in his arms, the world is bright' [29]. But her conclusion that, whatever her man is, she is his forevermore indicates that she is willing to live with any discrepancy that may exist between the things she cares about, and that she will continue to love her man in spite of her recognition that he is a thoroughly obnoxious individual. Of this kind of scenario, Frankfurt says the following:

In that case, the love may be a misfortune; and it may be a still further misfortune for someone to become aware that what he loves has no special worth. But such things happen [30].

This response may leave us feeling rather dissatisfied. And this is so, I think, for reasons to which T. M. Scanlon draws our attention when he appeals to our intuition that '[p]eople value many things that are not in fact valuable' [31]. He illustrates this claim by way of the contrast he draws between friendship and 'fanship'. As he explains, fanship is:

the state of being a devoted admirer of some famous person, such as a movie star, a singer or an athlete. Some people value fanship. That is, they think that

being a fan makes life better, more enjoyable, and more interesting. They may also think it is important to be a good fan: that there is good reason, say, to see all the movies in which their favorite star appears as soon as they come out, and to defend the star when others criticize, and that it would be a great thing to see the star in person, even from a great distance [32].

Scanlon is appealing here to our intuition that fanship, so described, just is not valuable. And this, I suggest, is also the cause of the unease we feel about the jazz singer's attachment to her man. We want to say *more* than that this is unfortunate, but such things happen. We want to say that these people value something that is *not valuable*; in caring as they do, they make a *mistake*. And Scanlon proceeds to tell us just what we want to hear:

According to the account of value I am suggesting, to hold that fanship is not valuable is just to hold that these reasons [for valuing fanship] are not good reasons, or at least that a person who gave them great weight in shaping his life would be making a mistake [33].

In other words, Scanlon is suggesting that in order to care in the best way, one must have good reasons for caring about the object in question, whether that object be fanship, one's man, or anything else for that matter. Therefore, we can say that unconditional love is necessarily an impoverished mode of caring because it directly rules out any appeal to reasons. Frankfurt's account of love is unconditional in this sense because he denies the existence of any such objective reasons. Here then is the problem: while it is true that what we want to think is that the fan must be making a mistake on the ground that his or her reasons look like bad reasons, it is not clear who *we* are to say that the fan's reasons are bad reasons. The *fan* thinks them good reasons. And without employing a dubiously metaphysical account to allow us to distinguish good reasons from bad, it is very difficult to see how we are going to show the fan that he or she is making a mistake. It is difficult, that is, to see why it is not open to Frankfurt, when we all cry out that fanship is without value, to retort, 'without value for whom?'

I find Frankfurt's objection compelling, but the jazz singer still haunts. For she appears to *recognise* that any reasons she might find for loving her man would be bad reasons. As she observes, 'I don't know why I should [love him]'. She is not deluded about his character; she just doesn't care. Presumably Scanlon would regard this as downright pathological and would dismiss the attachment as pure infatuation and, as such, utterly valueless, and perhaps it is. However, it is once again very difficult to see why Frankfurt cannot retort, 'valueless for whom?' But perhaps it is worth now pursuing the 'for whom' part of this response a little further. For what if the person condemning the attachment as worthless is the jazz singer herself as she looks back upon what she now perceives as her tragically wasted life?

The scenario, then, is this: the jazz singer, having finally broken with her man and having been apart from him for some considerable period of time reflects upon the relationship. She considers herself, in part, a different person now, having committed the 'slow and painful suicide of that self which loved' [34]. She now describes the attachment as worthless. Is it open to Frankfurt to retort to *her* 'worthless for whom?' I suspect that it probably is. In accordance with Frankfurt's account she could, and she

quite possibly would, say that there were no good reasons (in her view, from *here*) to have loved the man as she did *then* and that it is unfortunate, perhaps tragic, that she did love him. What it is not open to her to say, on Frankfurt's argument, is that it was not worth her loving him *at the time*, or that it was a mistake *then* simply because she disapproves of it *now*. For at that time, and for her as she was then constituted, it clearly was worth it. The reason it does not seem worthwhile now is simply that she cares about different things now. In the relevant respect — that of loving or not loving the man — she is a different person. It is not clear how we are to decide which perspective is authoritative. Of course, this issue gives rise to difficult questions about the nature of personal identity and I do not intend to address these, but it seems to me that Frankfurt's account can still emerge with its plausibility intact and, as a result, his account still poses a threat to our intuition that people can value worthless things.

4. I have been arguing that Frankfurt's conception of love holds up in spite of profound intuitions we hold to the contrary about the nature of love. This conclusion provokes (I hope) discomfort for most of us. But now I want to suggest that perhaps this discomfort may be significant, for it draws our attention to what I suspect may turn out to be a very important distinction. Even if Frankfurt is correct and love is not grounded in reasons, this does not entail that, in love, reasons do not *matter*. We can perfectly consistently hold that, while our love is not dependent upon the existence of reasons, our love is dependent upon our willingness to search for reasons that may serve to render the love intelligible. It is this last thought that I will now address.

On the face of it, it looks as though our intuition that reasons for loving must matter may be explained in the following ways. First, they matter because it is important to us that we do not waste our lives; we want to ensure that our beloved is as we believe him or her to be. Thus, it seems that we should want to check that the way in which we view the beloved coincides (to some degree at least) with the way in which others view him. It would make me uneasy, that is to say, if it were the case that, whilst I regarded my beloved as an extremely honest and virtuous person, everybody else who knew her regarded her as a liar and a cheat. Secondly, reasons matter because we do not want to have to look back upon our lives with regret, as an ex-fan might, about the way in which we had misjudged the value of the object of our devotion. Here the concern is not about the accuracy of our reasons, but rather their quality. I would not, that is to say, when reflecting upon my life, wish to notice that I used to cite as a reason for finding my beloved lovable the adorable way in which she kicked homeless people as she passed them in the street. Given that we do not want to have to look back upon our wasted lives with regret, one might think that we had better make certain right now that the one we love is worthy of our devotion.

However, it cannot be the case (or at least it cannot in *all* cases be true) that this will suffice as a complete explanation of why a concern for reasons should arise. This is because these concerns for reasons appear to be prompted by further concerns — the concern that I might be wasting my life on a worthless object — which, *qua lover* with integrated will, I cannot practically have. As Frankfurt explains:

Suppose that our love is so wholehearted, and that we are so satisfied to be in its grip, that we could not bring ourselves to undermine it even if ways in

which it could be undermined were available to us. In that case, the issue of whether it is a good idea for us to love as we do is one that we could not take seriously. As a practical matter it cannot effectively arise [35].

And this is exemplified in the case of the jazz singer. It does not matter that she may at some point look back upon her life with regret, for *now*, as she sings her song, she loves in a sufficiently wholehearted manner that those reasons to which she draws our attention ('two or three girls has he . . . he isn't true, he beats me too') are not reasons that she is able to take seriously. Indeed, for her, they do not even have the status of reasons.

In order for reasons to become important to us (presuming that our will is integrated), our concern for them must arise from the love we feel for the beloved. Recall Frankfurt's remark that, love 'creates the reasons by which acts of loving devotion are inspired' [36]. If, therefore, it can be shown that the search for reasons to render intelligible one's loving as one does is an act of loving devotion, an act, that is to say, which is inspired by love, then we can show that reasons matter to us, in love, in a way that does not conflict with Frankfurt's account. This is precisely what I want now to suggest. I want to argue that reasons must matter, for if they did not, we could have no confidence that our love was not arbitrary, and, in the best kind of love, we care too much about the beloved to allow it to be the case that our love is arbitrary.

5. The understanding of love propounded by Frankfurt does look rather arbitrary. 'Proper' love is only distinguished from infatuation, on Frankfurt's account, by the fact that the demands the commitment places upon the agent are seen as being authentically his. Love is thus a matter of authenticity or integrity. And this might trouble us, for it seems to ignore our intuition that the best kinds of loves are '*well-grounded*' loves; loves, that is to say, which are supported not only by the integrity of the lover's will, but also by considerations of a more objective kind. Consider the following example. You are at a party and an attractive stranger whom you have never met before approaches you and says, 'I find you extremely attractive'. You might be somewhat taken aback by this (or perhaps this happens to you all the time), but, in any case, I imagine that most of us would feel quite flattered. But how would you feel if the same stranger approached you and said 'I am completely in love with you. I've been watching you for the last minute now and I know I'm in love. Whatever you are, whatever you become, I am yours forever'? Most of us, I suspect, would feel quite afraid. But also, would we not say, or at least think, something like the following: 'Don't be ridiculous. Of course you don't love me; you don't even know me. You caught sight of me for the first time in your life a minute ago; how can your profession of love mean anything?'

To be fair to Frankfurt's position, it might be true that a person just could not plausibly come to identify authentically with her commitment to another in such a short period of time. But would it really make us feel any more convinced by the stranger's declaration of love if she explained that in fact she had been aware of our existence for the past six months? It is not clear to me that it necessarily would: time of itself does not render the declaration any less arbitrary. But, for Frankfurt, this can certainly be love, and a rather profound manifestation of it at that! It must be possible that a person can feel impelled to take a disinterested concern in the flourishing of a

person he has never actually met before and about whom he knows almost nothing. Moreover, it must be conceivable that, given time, he could authentically identify with that impulsion. Why, then, would we want to dismiss such a clear and intense profession of genuine love as being at best impoverished, and quite possibly altogether meaningless? Part of the reason we dismiss it, I think, is because it strikes us as being far too arbitrary. For sure, it might be true that in the time following her initial sighting of us, we may have become utterly integral to this stranger's self-conception such that she could no longer imagine herself apart from us. But her profession of unconditional love says nothing definite about *us*; it says little or nothing about our qualities. All it really says is that we have become central to somebody else's self-conception in a manner with which he or she is able to identify. Well, so what? Are we supposed to infer from this that the stranger is really in love with us? Surely not.

The best kind of love, it seems, must be conditional in the sense that it must not be arbitrary. However, Frankfurt argues that, since we cannot help loving what we love, '[w]e cannot fairly be charged with arbitrariness, or with a willful lack of objectivity, since these things are not under our control at all' [37]. My example of the stranger at the party was told from the perspective of the beloved object, not that of the lover. As such, Frankfurt might argue that it is irrelevant, for what if the lover just does not care about the perspective of the beloved? Well, if not, then it may be correct to suggest that this is love of a sort, but surely any lover would be hard pressed to explain how such a love, which cared not about the perspective of the beloved, could be regarded as the *best* kind of love. I want now to explore this thought in some detail. I shall claim that, in the best kind of love, a concern about arbitrariness or objectivity is implicit in that love itself. The search for reasons to ground our love should matter to us just because we love authentically. If this is so, the best kind of love may have to incorporate more than one perspective on its object.

Two Perspectives

1. The stranger at the party was overwhelmed by a compulsion with which she identified. Both she and Frankfurt agree that this is love, and who are we to argue? It certainly seems that, from the perspective of the lover, Frankfurt is correct, it is not clear that the issue of whether the commitment in question is worth it *need* arise and it is not clear that it is open to us to dismiss such attachments as mere infatuations. From the narrowly subjective perspective of the lover, it is not clear that there is much more to be said on the matter. Nevertheless, it seems that, for most of us, there remains a great deal more to be said. Most, I suspect, could identify with my portrayal of the beloved's response to the stranger's advances at the party. Indeed, I do not think you need even conceive of yourself as the beloved object in order to form such a conclusion. Suppose you were an onlooker at the party who witnessed the declaration of love. Would you not think much the same as the object of the stranger's affections — 'Don't be ridiculous, of course you don't *really* love that person, you know next to nothing about him/her'?

This worry, recognisable from the 'outside', that even the strongest feelings of love may be arbitrary is one with which many of us can identify. Were we not able to identify with this portrayal of love, a vast swathe of our literary heritage, which is

replete with such examples, would be incomprehensible to us. We would be incapable of making sense of Swann's realisation that he had *wasted* years of his life on Odette, of Dorothea's recognition that her feelings for Casaubon were *misplaced*, of Isabel Archer's realisation that she was *mistaken* to have been devoted to Gilbert Osmond upon her discovery that he was not the man she had supposed him to be, of Fermina Daza's claim, in a letter to Florentino Ariza, that, 'Today, when I saw you, I realized that what is between us is nothing more than an illusion' [38]. All of these examples, and a multitude of others, presuppose that it is possible for us to think ourselves in love, when in fact (as we may later perceive) we are not *really* in love at all. If it is a part of our understanding of love that such commitments are capable of being mistaken or arbitrary, then the best kind of love will surely recognise this threat and seek to eliminate it.

I am thus proposing that, since we regard the best kind of love as a well-grounded love, we recognise the significance of not one, but two perspectives on that love. There is the narrowly subjective perspective as exemplified by the jazz singer and the stranger at the party, but for those who really care, this portrayal must be supplemented by another: a more biographical perspective that takes into consideration how the commitment might be understood by others. This thought derives intuitive plausibility from a consideration of the way in which we understand certain works of literature and the way in which we understand the nature of regret in our own lives. It is not clear to me that being in love with a person should suddenly render us incapable of understanding such considerations. So my suggestion is that, while we love, cases like these will haunt us. Moreover, they *should* haunt us; for to force them from our minds would be to offend against the things we profess to care about.

2. Why might we think it a characteristic of the best kind of love that the lover will take an interest in the way in which the commitment may be perceived from the outside? We might think our disinterested concern for the happiness of the beloved should prompt such an interest. A large part of what we value about being the object of another's love is that we take it to imply an informed and positive (or at least not negative), objective evaluation of our character, we think of love as being more than the arbitrary expression of a subjective whim. We want to know that there exist reasons that can render this person's love for us intelligible to others. Where a person's declaration of love appears to lack this element of implicit objective evaluation, where it strikes us as being in this sense indiscriminate, we feel that it means less than it otherwise might have done. Suppose, for instance, that the jazz singer declared her love for you. While, on one level, you might feel flattered by such a declaration, it is not clear how meaningful that declaration could ultimately be. We know that the jazz singer is fully prepared sincerely to declare her love for those who lie to her, beat her and cheat on her; her declaration of love is thus entirely independent of any evaluation of the beloved and is, as such, entirely compatible with her believing that the object of her love is a thoroughly nasty individual. Surely many of us would be tempted to think that this fact serves, in some way, to belittle her declaration of love. While we need not suppose that it could even begin to explain the true *basis* of the love, I submit that most of us would like to think that when a person declares her love for us, she is also implicitly declaring her sincere belief that it would in principle be possible to provide some account of why we are worthy of that love.

Conclusion

Not everybody will be persuaded by the case I have put here. Indeed, it seems open to Frankfurt to object to my argument that it is not in fact inconsistent with his. For the claim I am making requires that a person care not only about his or her beloved, but also about the non-subjective worth of his or her beloved. I do not think that Frankfurt need deny the *possibility* of this. The force of his sceptical challenge is that *for the most part* these two commitments will not coincide in the mind of one person [39]. For Frankfurt, most of us are confined to the narrowly subjective conception of love and are just incapable of making the conceptual leap to the question of whether our love is or is not arbitrary in the minds of others. In the case of the people Frankfurt imagines, let us call them “incurable romantics”, it is not clear that my argument will make any headway.

However, I wish to make two further, and final, points in defence of my position. First, I hope that the case I have made has demonstrated that fewer of us are actually incurable romantics than Frankfurt’s account appears to suppose. The fact is that most of us can and do recognise that, even while we are deeply within love’s grip, any love is capable of being mistaken or arbitrary. Moreover, most of us do take an interest in seeking to ensure that *our* love is not like that. That there do exist *some* truly incurable romantics in the world who are completely impervious to any argument on this front need not worry us unduly. Secondly, I have denied the thought that recognition of both portrayals of love (the narrowly subjective and the non-subjective) symbolises the disruption of a will divided between two competing commitments, as Frankfurt would have it. My argument has been that the two are not incompatible. On the contrary, a heightened concern for the non-subjective perspective flows, as an act of loving devotion, from our narrowly subjective concerns. By seeking reasons to render our love intelligible we may come to a richer understanding of our beloved and of her place in the world. It would surely be odd to view this desire as some kind of assault on our love, much more plausible to view it as an expression of our devotion. This is an important point, for it supports my previous observation. Given that caring makes the non-subjective perspective more important than it otherwise would be, even those with a relatively latent commitment to that perspective can be shown, through argument, how caring should prompt them to give it more weight in their lives. Thus, I do not claim to have defeated Frankfurt’s argument; for the most part I agree with him. Rather, I claim to have defused the more worrying implications of his thesis. While I have not provided a means by which we can condemn the jazz singer’s love as worthless, I have suggested that it might be possible to say rather more to her than ‘Sorry, but such things happen’ [40].

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NOTES

[1] M. YVAIN and C. POLLOCK (1985) *My Man (Mon Homme)*, performed by Billie Holiday on *The Legend of Billie Holiday* (MCA Records inc.).

[2] G. TAYLOR (1976) *Love*, *Proceedings of the Aristotelian Society*, LXXVI, p. 151.

[3] *op. cit.*, note 1.

- [4] M. PROUST (1992) *In Search of Lost Time*, vol. 5 (London, Vintage), p. 647.
- [5] R. NOZICK (1989) Love's bond in his *The Examined Life: Philosophical Meditations* (New York, Touchstone), p. 75.
- [6] *Ibid.*, p. 75.
- [7] N. DELANEY (1996) Romantic love and loving commitment: articulating a modern ideal, *American Philosophical Quarterly*, 33, 4, pp. 339–56; S. KELLER (2000) How do I Love Thee? Let me Count the Properties, *American Philosophical Quarterly*, 37, 2, pp. 163–73; M. LEVINE (1999) Loving individuals for their Properties or, what was the colour of Yeats's mother's hair?, *Iyyun, The Jerusalem Philosophical Quarterly*, 48, pp. 251–67.
- [8] M. PROUST (1992) *In Search of Lost Time*, vol. 4 (London, Vintage), pp. 610–1.
- [9] Keller, op. cit., note 7, p. 170.
- [10] *Ibid.*, p. 170.
- [11] Something like this point is made, albeit in terms of psychoanalytic theory, by M. Levine, op. cit., note 7, pp. 262–66.
- [12] S. MENDUS (2001) Marital faithfulness in her *Feminism and Emotion: Readings in Moral and Political Philosophy* (Houndmills, Macmillan), p. 75.
- [13] Arguments of this form are presented by M. BERNSTEIN (1985) Love, particularity, and selfhood, *Southem Journal of Philosophy*, 23, pp. 287–93; Delaney, N. op. cit., note 7; Levine, M. op. cit., note 7; and J. RAZ (2001) *Value, Respect and Attachment* (Cambridge, Cambridge University Press).
- [14] Raz, op. cit., note 13, p. 30. Though it is worth noting that some argue that shared history does represent a property of the beloved. cf. Levine, op. cit., note 7.
- [15] See for example Bernstein's (op. cit., note 13.) reflections upon how he would feel when presented with the news that the following day his wife, Diane, was to be replaced by the rather ominously titled Diane*.
- [16] H. FRANKFURT (2001) *Some Mysteries of Love* [The Lindley Lecture, 2000] (Lawrence, Department of Philosophy, University of Kansas), p. 5.
- [17] *Ibid.*, p. 5.
- [18] H. FRANKFURT (1988) The importance of what we care about, in his, *The Importance of What We Care About: Philosophical Essays* (Cambridge, Cambridge University Press), p. 86.
- [19] op. cit., note 16, p. 3.
- [20] ALAIN-FOURNIER (1959) *Le Grand Meaulnes* (London, Oxford University Press) p. 162.
- [21] FRANKFURT, H. (1999) Autonomy, necessity and love in his *Necessity, Volition, and Love* (Cambridge, Cambridge University Press), p. 137.
- [22] *Ibid.*, p. 137.
- [23] op. cit., note 16, p. 4.
- [24] op. cit., note 16, p. 8.
- [25] M. PROUST (1992) *In Search of Lost Time* vol. 2 (London, Vintage), p. 215.
- [26] Though one might think this kind of story rather odious. It is tempting to say that a person who found his commitments this easy to revoke could never *really* have been in love at all.
- [27] G. GARCIA MARQUEZ (1989) *Love in the Time of Cholera* (London, Penguin), p. 102.
- [28] op. cit., note 16, p. 4.
- [29] op. cit., note 1.
- [30] op. cit., note 16, p. 3.
- [31] T. M. SCANLON (1998) *What We Owe to Each Other* (Cambridge, Mass., Harvard University Press), p. 89.
- [32] *Ibid.*, p. 89.
- [33] *Ibid.*, pp. 89–90.
- [34] M. PROUST (1992) *In Search of Lost Time* vol. 2 (London, Vintage), p. 215.
- [35] op. cit., note 16, p. 8.
- [36] op. cit., note 16, p. 3.
- [37] op. cit., note 16, p. 8.
- [38] op. cit., note 27, p. 102.
- [39] As Frankfurt says of Kantian morality, 'It is not very likely, in my opinion, that what each of us considers most important to himself is exactly the same. It seems to me even less likely that the one thing about which each of us cares most is the moral law.' H. FRANKFURT (1999) Autonomy, necessity and love in his *Necessity, Volition, and Love* (Cambridge, Cambridge University Press), p. 132.

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